Looking Up: The Night Sky Over Billingborough

13 November – 11 December 2026

A practical guide to the most interesting astronomical events visible from Billingborough

As late autumn gives way to early winter, the lengthening nights over Lincolnshire bring a rich mix of planetary pairings, meteor activity and classic winter star clusters. Mid-November opens with a spectacular morning planetary alignment and the Leonid meteor shower, followed by the full Beaver Moon and Uranus reaching opposition.

At a glance

Date	Event	What to look for
14–15 November	**Morning planet alignment**	Spot Mercury, Venus, Jupiter and Mars stretching up from the southeastern horizon before dawn.
17–18 November	**Leonid meteor shower**	Fast meteors originating from Comet 55P/Tempel-Tuttle, radiating from the constellation Leo.
20 November	**Moon near Saturn**	Use the waxing gibbous Moon to locate Saturn in the southern evening sky.
24 November	**Full Beaver Moon & the Pleiades**	The full Moon rises at dusk and passes close to the Seven Sisters open star cluster.
25 November	**Venus at maximum brightness**	Venus shines at its most brilliant for the year in the pre-dawn eastern sky.
25 November	**Uranus at opposition**	The distant ice giant lies opposite the Sun, visible all night as a faint binocular target.
30 November	**Moon, Jupiter, Mars & Regulus**	A striking pre-dawn gathering in Leo for naked-eye and binocular observers.

Date	Event	What to look for
5 December	**Crescent Moon near Venus**	A beautifully slender waning crescent Moon sits close to dazzling Venus before sunrise.

14–15 November – A pre-dawn planetary alignment

Early risers looking southeast about 45 to 60 minutes before sunrise will be treated to a line-up of four planets. Stretching upwards from the horizon, you can spot Mercury, brilliant Venus, Jupiter and Mars. Jupiter and Mars will appear highest and bunched closely together, while Venus blazes unmistakably below them. Mercury sits lowest and will require a clear, flat eastern or southeastern horizon to spot.



The pre-dawn southeastern sky over Billingborough on 14 November, showing Mercury, Venus, Jupiter and Mars.

17–18 November – The Leonid meteor shower

The Leonids peak during the evening of 17 November into the early hours of 18 November. This shower is created as Earth passes through the trail of tiny debris left behind by Comet 55P/Tempel-Tuttle. These cometary particles enter our atmosphere at speeds of up to 70 kilometres per second, vaporising to create fast, bright streaks of light.

The meteors appear to originate—or radiate—from the 'sickle' or head of the constellation Leo the Lion, which gives the shower its name. With the waxing gibbous Moon setting just before midnight, the dark early-morning hours are ideal for watching. Under optimal conditions, you might see 10 to 15 meteors per hour. Choose a dark spot away from local lights, let your eyes adapt for 20 minutes, and scan a wide area of sky rather than staring directly at Leo.

20 November – The Moon passes Saturn

During the evening of 20 November, the waxing gibbous Moon can be seen 5.4° north of Saturn in the southern sky. Although the bright Moon will wash out fainter background stars, it serves as an unmistakable signpost to the ringed planet.

24 November – The full Beaver Moon and the Pleiades

November's full Moon is traditionally known as the Beaver Moon. As it rises around sunset, it will pass near the Pleiades (M45) in Taurus. While the intense moonlight will overwhelm the cluster's fainter members to the unaided eye, binoculars will reveal the brightest blue-white stars of the Seven Sisters gleaming beside the lunar limb.

25 November – Glorious Venus at its brightest

Venus has been putting on a spectacular show as a brilliant morning star in the east-southeastern pre-dawn sky. Around 25 November, it reaches its greatest brightness of 2026, shining at a magnitude of −4.89.

If you point a telescope at Venus right now, you won't see a fully illuminated disc; it will appear as a crescent that is only about 23% illuminated. You might wonder how a planet can shine so brilliantly when we can see less than a quarter of its sunlit side. The answer lies in orbital geometry: Venus is currently swinging relatively close to Earth, making its crescent appear physically much larger in our sky than when the planet is fully illuminated but on the far side of the Sun.

25 November – Uranus at opposition

Uranus reaches opposition on 25 November, meaning it is directly opposite the Sun from Earth and visible all night. Because it is a faint target, you will need binoculars to distinguish it from the background stars. Since the bright full Moon sits in the sky at the same time, the most rewarding strategy is to wait until early December, when darker skies make star-hopping to this distant ice giant much easier.

30 November – A dawn gathering in Leo

Before sunrise on 30 November, the waning Moon glides past Jupiter, Mars and the bright star Regulus. At 05:40 UT, the Moon will sit 2.1° southwest of Jupiter. Nearby, Jupiter will be 3.5° northwest of Regulus, and Mars will sit 2.3° northeast of Regulus. This makes for a compact, eye-catching arrangement high in the pre-dawn sky, providing an excellent wide-field target for binoculars.



The pre-dawn southern sky over Billingborough on 30 November, showing the Moon, Jupiter, Mars and Regulus.

5 December – Crescent Moon near Venus

For those up before dawn, look low towards the southeast to spot a delicate crescent Moon sitting near dazzling Venus. This pairing provides a stunning naked-eye sight and an excellent photo opportunity above the local landscape.

A good four weeks for observing

The next four weeks reward early risers, with the magnificent morning planetary alignment, the dazzling mechanics of Venus at its brightest, and dark-sky Leonid meteors after midnight. In the evening sky, opposition-bright Uranus provides a steady binocular challenge before December's new Moon hands the stage over to Orion and the winter clusters. Wrap up well against the late-autumn chill, check the local cloud forecast before setting up, and enjoy the crisp transparency that cold nights often bring.

Sources and checking

Astronomical data and observing guidance prepared using ephemeris calculations for Billingborough (52.89° N, 0.34° W), alongside the British Astronomical Association, Royal Observatory Greenwich and NASA's Sky Events Calendar. Exact chart framing and local altitude times were verified in Stellarium.